

STAGE NINE • ENGLISH VOCABULARY FIRST SET

FIRSTS

DISCUSSION PROMPTS

Open-ended questions to seed group conversation beyond the worksheets

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Discussion Prompts

Stage Nine • English Vocabulary First Set

PURPOSE

Individual worksheets in this stage test whether a word or phrase can be used correctly. These prompts ask a different, complementary question: what's your real, lived relationship to language and communication itself? They're open-ended and personal, meant to seed conversation beyond simply reviewing vocabulary lists.

For a stage this vocabulary-dense, these prompts do real work beyond just filling time — they give participants a reason to actually care about a word list by connecting it to a genuine memory or experience, which tends to help retention more than repetition alone.

Use these during natural pauses, when a session finishes its planned agenda with time to spare, or specifically to break up a session that's had a lot of drilling in a row. They're organized by session, four prompts each. As with every stage, pick the one or two that feel most alive for the room rather than working through all four every time.

Prompts by Session

SESSION 1

Core Vocabulary Building Blocks

"What's a word on this list you technically knew but have never actually used yourself? What's stopped you?"

"Have you ever used a big or impressive-sounding word incorrectly and gotten caught? What happened?"

"Which of these twenty adjectives feels most genuinely true of you right now, today?"

"What's an idiom or phrase from your own first language that doesn't translate well into English? What does it actually mean?"

SESSION 2

Written & Documentation Vocabulary

"Have you ever received an email so overly formal it actually made the message harder to understand?"

"What's the most confusing set of meeting notes you've ever tried to make sense of after the fact?"

"Is there a phrase you overuse in your own writing without realizing it? How did you find out?"

"What's the difference, in your own words, between a report that sounds confident and one that sounds arrogant?"

SESSION 3

Meeting & Verbal Communication Vocabulary

"What's your honest instinct when you disagree with someone in a meeting — do you say so, or stay quiet? Why?"

"Have you ever given feedback that came out harsher, or softer, than you actually meant it to?"

"What's a follow-up message you've been avoiding sending? What's actually stopping you?"

"Describe a time someone genuinely made you feel heard in a conversation. What did they actually do?"

SESSION 4

Presentation & Persuasion Vocabulary

"What's the best presentation opener you've ever personally heard? What made it work?"

"Have you ever been asked a question during a presentation that you genuinely couldn't answer? What did you do?"

"What's the difference between a presentation that informs you and one that actually persuades you to act?"

"What's your biggest personal fear about public speaking, specifically — not the general idea, the actual moment?"

SESSION 5

Self-Presentation & Networking Vocabulary

"What's a greeting or introduction habit from a different culture or language you genuinely admire?"

"Have you ever completely blanked during a self-introduction? What happened, and what would you do differently now?"

"What's your honest relationship with small talk — do you enjoy it, tolerate it, or dread it?"

"What's an everyday workplace phrase you've picked up recently that you didn't know a year ago?"

SESSION 6

Problem-Solving & Growth Vocabulary

"What's a challenge you've struggled to explain clearly to someone else, even though it felt obvious in your own head?"

"Describe a time someone proposed an alternative to your idea that actually turned out to be better."

"What's a decision where the pros and cons genuinely felt evenly matched? How did you eventually choose?"

"Looking back at this entire vocabulary stage, what's one word or phrase you know you'll actually keep using?"